and reach 273 without loss when Marcus Trescothick finally edges the ball. My feet are going one way, the ball is going another way, but I hold the catch and am soon submerged by celebrating teammates.

England's mammoth second-innings score means that, after dominating the first two days, we suddenly find ourselves under pressure and batting to save the Test on the last day. I come to the crease at 173 for six after debutant Hashim Amla is out. Martin van Jaarsveld goes soon afterwards. England are hunting for the win but, in fading light, Shaun Pollock and I fight hard for 27 overs. We survive. The Test is drawn and I finish on 52 not out.

Playing strokes and scoring runs is great but, first and foremost, I want to be known as a fighter, so the rearguard action feels good.

The series moves to Cape Town for the third Test, and Kallis leads the way again, scoring 149. I am keeping wicket again and score only 21 when batting at seven in the first innings and just 10 when batting at eight in the second innings. Amid these failures, Test cricket is starting to feel a little more challenging than seemed the case in Port Elizabeth.

England are eventually set 501 to win and, after I manage to stump Robert Key off the bowling of Nicky Boje, they are dismissed for 304. We win the third Test by 196 runs and level the series at 1–1.

Heading to the Highveld for the fourth Test at the Wanderers, Mark Boucher is rightly recalled to keep wicket and I remain in the middle order, batting at six. I start reasonably well in the first innings and bat for an hour, reaching 19, including three boundaries, but then Hoggard bowls a bouncer; I can't resist the temptation to hook and am caught at fine leg.

The Test continues and we are ultimately set 325 to win in the fourth innings. I am promoted to open with Herschelle Gibbs after Graeme Smith is concussed during the warm-up but I am dismissed for three, LBW to Hoggard, falling forward again, getting my weight distribution wrong again, and we are bowled out for 247, defeated by 77 runs.